

ATS-friendly formatting

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Before a human recruiter ever sees a resume, it is very often parsed by an Applicant Tracking System (ATS) — software that extracts text, matches keywords against the job description, and ranks or filters candidates before a human review stage. A visually striking resume with multi-column layouts, graphics, or unusual fonts can look great to a human eye but parse as garbled or incomplete text to an ATS, silently dropping a qualified candidate before anyone ever reads it. This sub-module covers exactly what makes a resume ATS-parseable — layout choices, standard section headings, keyword alignment with the job description, safe file formats — so that formatting choices never become the reason a resume is filtered out before it's even read by a person.

1. What ATS Software Actually Does

An ATS extracts raw text from an uploaded resume file, organizes it into fields (contact info, experience, education, skills), and often scores or ranks candidates by keyword match against the job description before a recruiter opens anything. Critically, an ATS parses structure, not visual layout — it doesn't 'see' a nicely designed two-column resume the way a human does; it reads text in whatever order its parser extracts it, which for complex layouts can scramble content into an unreadable order (e.g., pulling a skills sidebar and merging it mid-sentence into the experience section).

2. Layout Rules That Keep Parsing Clean

The safest, most universally ATS-compatible layout is a single column, top-to-bottom structure using standard section headings, without tables, text boxes, images, icons, or multi-column layouts, all of which risk being misread or dropped entirely by different ATS parsers. This doesn't mean the resume has to look plain or unpolished — clean typography, consistent spacing, and simple bold/section-divider formatting are all fine and ATS-safe; it's specifically structural complexity (tables, columns, embedded graphics, headers/footers with contact info) that causes parsing problems.

- Safe: a single-column resume with bold section headings ('Experience', 'Education', 'Skills', 'Projects') and plain bullet points.

- Risky: a two-column layout with a skills sidebar, a headshot photo, icons next to contact details, or contact info placed in a document header/footer (many parsers skip headers/footers entirely).

3. Standard Section Headings and Fonts

ATS software is often tuned to recognize conventional section names — 'Work Experience' or 'Professional Experience', 'Education', 'Skills', 'Projects', 'Certifications' — and creative renaming ('My Journey', 'What I Bring to the Table') can cause a parser to fail to categorize that section's content correctly, effectively hiding it from the keyword match even if the content itself is strong. Similarly, standard, widely-supported fonts (Arial, Calibri, Times New Roman, Georgia) parse reliably; decorative or unusual fonts can occasionally cause character-recognition issues in older parsers.

4. Keyword Optimization Against the Job Description

Because many ATS systems rank candidates partly by keyword overlap with the job description, deliberately mirroring the specific terms used in the posting — exact skill names, tools, and role-specific phrases — measurably improves how a resume is scored, provided those skills are genuinely possessed. If a job description says 'proficient in SQL and Power BI' and a resume only says 'worked with databases and dashboards,' a keyword-matching parser may score it lower even though the underlying skills substantially overlap. This is not about keyword-stuffing irrelevant terms; it's about using the same specific vocabulary the employer used, when it accurately describes your actual experience.

- If the JD says 'Python, Pandas, SQL' — and your project used those exact tools — write 'Python, Pandas, SQL' on the resume, not a vaguer paraphrase like 'data analysis tools.'

5. File Format Considerations

PDF is generally safe with modern ATS software and is the most common recommendation because it preserves formatting exactly across devices, but a small minority of older or poorly configured ATS systems parse .docx more reliably than PDF. When a job posting doesn't specify a format, PDF is the safer default; when in doubt or when a portal explicitly recommends .docx, following that specific instruction is safer than defaulting to a personal preference. Regardless of format, the file should be exported from a text-based source (a real document), never a scanned image or a photograph of a printed resume, since ATS software cannot reliably extract text from an image.

6. Common ATS Parsing Failures

The most damaging parsing failures are often invisible to the candidate because the resume looks fine when opened normally — the problem only shows up in how the ATS extracts it. Contact information placed inside a header or footer is a frequent silent failure, since many parsers skip headers/footers entirely, meaning a strong resume gets rejected simply because the system couldn't find a phone number or email at all. Similarly, resumes built from a heavily templated design (common in some resume-builder tools) that relies on tables or text boxes for layout can have entire sections dropped or scrambled during parsing.

7. Testing Your Resume for ATS Compatibility

A simple, practical test before submitting a resume anywhere is to copy all text out of the PDF/document and paste it into a plain text editor — if the pasted text comes out in a garbled, out-of-order, or incomplete state, an ATS parser will very likely have the same problem. Several free online ATS-checker tools also simulate this parsing and flag missing sections or low keyword match against a pasted job description; while these tools aren't perfectly identical to every real ATS, they catch the most common structural problems (headers/footers, tables, missing standard section names) before submission.

Common Pitfalls

- Using a multi-column or template-heavy layout that looks polished but parses as scrambled or incomplete text.
- Placing contact information (phone, email) inside a document header or footer, which many ATS parsers skip entirely.
- Renaming standard sections creatively ('My Journey' instead of 'Experience'), causing a parser to miscategorize the content.
- Using tables, text boxes, or embedded icons for layout, which can be dropped or garbled during parsing.
- Submitting a scanned image or photo of a resume instead of a real text-based document.
- Never checking the job description for exact keyword phrasing and instead using vaguer paraphrases.
- Assuming a resume that looks fine when opened is automatically fine for ATS — never testing the actual parsed text.

Key Takeaways

- ATS software parses structure, not visual design — simple single-column layouts are the safest choice.
- Use standard section headings ('Experience', 'Education', 'Skills') so parsers correctly categorize content.
- Mirror the exact keyword phrasing from the job description wherever it accurately reflects your real experience.
- Keep contact info in the document body, never only in a header or footer.
- PDF is generally safe by default; follow a portal's explicit format instruction when one is given.
- Test parsing yourself by copy-pasting the resume text into a plain editor before submitting anywhere important.

Learn More

Indeed — How to Make Your Resume ATS-Friendly

<https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/resumes-cover-letters/ats-resume>

Jobscan — ATS Resume Checker and Guide

<https://www.jobscan.co/applicant-tracking-systems>

LinkedIn Help — Resume and Application Tips

<https://www.linkedin.com/help/linkedin>